

A FREE DM TABLE · LONG ISLAND DUNGEON MASTER

THE WOODS ARE NOT EMPTY

What the forest is doing while the party walks through it.

d20, d12, d12, d20, d20 · no stat blocks · any temperate forest

Five small tables of what the forest is doing while the party walks through it. Animals, insects, small finds, foraging, and water.

Use **them** whenever the party is in woodland and you want the place to feel lived in. Nothing here attacks. Nothing here is a quest. Roll whichever table answers the question you have, ignore the rest, and read the row out as a plain thing that is happening. Every row works in any temperate forest, needs no stat block, and runs on rules you already have.

D20: WHAT YOU SEE IN THE TREES

D20 WHAT IS THERE

- | | |
|----|---|
| 1 | A doe is standing in the trail and does not move off, because her fawn is lying flat and folded in the leaves twenty feet away. |
| 2 | A pileated woodpecker is working a dead pine, and the chips coming off it are the size of a hand. |
| 3 | Six crows are mobbing a great horned owl, taking turns, and the owl has its eyes shut. |
| 4 | A red fox is hunting voles under the leaf litter, going up on its hind legs and coming down nose-first. |
| 5 | A porcupine is asleep in the crotch of a hemlock and will not be hurried. |
| 6 | Two bucks have locked antlers and one of them has been dead long enough that the other is dragging it. |
| 7 | A pine marten runs the length of a fallen trunk without once touching ground. |
| 8 | A barred owl calls in full daylight, twice, and something small stops moving in the brush. |
| 9 | A black bear has been at a rotten stump and torn it open lengthwise for the grubs. |
| 10 | A flock of turkeys crosses the trail in single file, eleven of them, and the last one waits. |
| 11 | A young buck is rubbing velvet off his antlers on a sapling and has stripped it to white wood. |
| 12 | A raven is flying with something bright in its beak and takes a route that avoids the open. |
| 13 | A bobcat's tracks run beside the trail for a quarter mile and then stop at a boulder. |
| 14 | An owl pellet lies under a roost tree, dry and grey, packed with mouse skulls. |
| 15 | A woodcock goes up underfoot with a noise like a wet whistle and drops again twenty yards on. |
| 16 | Deer have yarded up here for the winter and the ground is beaten flat for half an acre. |
| 17 | A weasel in half-changed coat, brown over white, watches from a stone wall. |
| 18 | A beaver-felled aspen is down across the trail with the cut end chewed to a point. |
| 19 | A hawk has plucked a pigeon on a stump, and the feathers are in a ring, and the ring is fresh. |
| 20 | Something large moved off through the laurel before anyone saw it, and the branches are still swinging. |



D12: INSECTS

D12 WHAT IS THERE

- | | |
|---|--|
| 1 | A column of ants has overtaken a beetle many times their size and is carrying it home in pieces. |
| 2 | Fireflies are rising out of the wet ground at dusk, and along one stretch of the treeline they are flashing in time. |
| 3 | The bugs at dusk have brought the bats, and they are swooping the clearing at head height. |
| 4 | A hatch has come off the water and the air above the stream is solid with mayflies that will all be dead by morning. |
| 5 | Two butterflies are spiralling upward around each other and keep climbing until they are out of sight. |
| 6 | Cicadas are so loud in this stand of oak that anyone speaking has to raise their voice. |

D12 WHAT IS THERE

- 7 A paper wasp nest the size of a lantern hangs at head height, still and busy.
- 8 Dew has caught every spider web in the hollow, and there are hundreds, and nobody noticed them yesterday.
- 9 A dung beetle is rolling a ball backwards up a slope and losing ground.
- 10 Caddisfly larvae in the shallows have built their cases out of sand grains, and one has used flecks of gold.
- 11 A dragonfly has just come out of its old skin on a reed stem and is hanging beside it, still soft, wings not yet hard.
- 12 Something has laid eggs in a neat row along the underside of every leaf on one branch.



D12: SMALL THINGS YOU FIND

D12 WHAT IS THERE

- 1 A nestling has come down and is alive in the leaves, mouth open, and the parents are close and shouting.
- 2 A hollow log has a family living in it, and there are three sets of eyes at the far end.
- 3 A turtle is crossing the trail, going somewhere, and going there slowly.
- 4 A shed snakeskin is hooked on a briar, whole, including the eyecaps.
- 5 A spring seep has frozen and thawed so many times the moss around it is armoured in ice lace.
- 6 A tree has grown around an iron ring and closed over it, and the ring is a foot off the ground.
- 7 An egg is lying whole in the middle of the path with nothing above it.
- 8 A deer skeleton is scattered across thirty feet and every bone has been gnawed at the ends.
- 9 A chestnut stump six feet across has sent up a ring of living shoots from its own roots.
- 10 Somebody's axe is sunk in a stump, rusted in, and the stump has grown up around the head.
- 11 A cluster of bright mushrooms has come up overnight in the shape of a rough circle.
- 12 A bird's nest built this spring has a length of red wool worked through it.



D20: FORAGING

D20 WHAT IS GROWING

- 1 Fiddleheads, tight and green, a patch of them along the wet edge.
- 2 Ramps, a whole hillside, and you smell them before you see them.
- 3 Morels, five of them, under a dying elm, and there are probably more.
- 4 Chanterelles coming up along a mossy bank, the colour of egg yolk.
- 5 Chicken-of-the-woods, bright orange, shelved up the side of a standing oak.
- 6 Hickory nuts under the tree by the hundred, and half of them already hollow.
- 7 Wild grapes high in a tree, sour, and worth the climb only just.
- 8 Blackberries in a thicket that will take skin off anyone reaching for the good ones.
- 9 A pawpaw, soft and heavy, that has already dropped.
- 10 Watercress in a cold spring run, peppery, and thick enough to fill a pack.

D20 WHAT IS GROWING

- 11 Cattails at the pond edge, the roots of which are worth more than the heads.
- 12 Acorns, many, and every one of them useless until somebody leaches them.
- 13 Hazelnuts, and the squirrels have been through here first and left the light ones.
- 14 Rose hips on a bramble by the old wall, still on after frost and better for it.
- 15 Wintergreen under the snow, one leaf of which changes a mouthful of water.
- 16 A birch that will run sap if it is tapped, and it is the right week for it.
- 17 Sumac heads, dark red, that make a sour drink and are easy to mistake for the white kind that does not.
- 18 Groundnut tubers strung along a root like beads, in wet ground, and hard work to get up.
- 19 A bee tree, humming, and the honey is forty feet up inside a hollow trunk.
- 20 Nothing worth eating for an hour in any direction, and the ground here has been picked over already.



D20: WATER

D20 WHAT THE WATER IS DOING

- 1 A beaver dam has backed the stream into a pond and drowned an acre of standing trees.
- 2 The water is tea-coloured from bog peat and stains everything it touches.
- 3 A plunge pool under a six-foot fall, deep, cold, and loud enough to cover conversation.
- 4 The stream goes into a crack in the rock and does not come out anywhere anyone can see.
- 5 A gravel bar has built up on the inside of the bend and the crossing is easy for once.
- 6 The bank is undercut and the whole edge is a lip of sod over open water.
- 7 A spring comes out of the hillside at the same temperature all year, and nothing freezes near it.
- 8 The pond has a mat of floating weed across it thick enough to hide the water.
- 9 Fish are stacked in the shade of one boulder and will not move for anything.
- 10 An old millpond, the dam breached long ago, and the stream now runs through the gap.
- 11 The riffle is shallow and fast and loud, and the pool below it is neither.
- 12 A dead tree has come down across the stream and everything floating has piled against it.
- 13 The water is so clear the bottom looks a foot down and is four.
- 14 Otters have worn a slide down the mud bank and used it recently.
- 15 A stream runs milky with rock flour and nothing lives in it.
- 16 Frogs are so loud at this pond after dark that nobody sleeps.
- 17 Heron tracks in the mud, and a lot of them, and the fish here know it.
- 18 The oxbow has been cut off from the river and is going green and still.
- 19 An iron spring runs orange over the stones and tastes of metal.
- 20 The ford is marked by two posts and the water between them is higher than the posts say it should be.

IF THIS WAS USEFUL

I write these because 30+ years of real tables has taught me that a forest the party walks through is a corridor, and a forest that is busy is a place.

Long Island Dungeon Master. 30+ years of real tables.

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